

A FEMALE CRUIOR.

An Indian Woman Who Lived Eighteen Years Alone on an Island in the Pacific.

[The Sanitarian.]

Mr. George Nidever, of Santa Barbara, has given a complete account of his discovery of a lone Indian woman on San Nicolas Island, in the Pacific Ocean, in 1883. Mr. Nidever is an enterprising man. He went to Santa Barbara in 1868, and found two other Americans, Isaac J. Sparks and Lewis T. Burton, engaged in the same business. They chartered a schooner of twenty tons burden, built at Monterey, called *Peer as Nela* (Better than Nothing), for a trip to the coast of Lower California, leaving Santa Barbara about the first of May, 1873. Mr. Nidever did not accompany them. Not being as successful as those in charge expected, three months later the *Peer as Nela* put into San Pedro, the port of landing of Los Angeles, on her return trip. From San Pedro she went to the Island of San Nicolas, about seventy miles southwest from San Pedro, and a little further south-west from Santa Barbara, for the purpose of securing the Indians then on the island to the main land, and returned with eighteen men, women, and children. How long the Indians had been residents of the island, how they got there, and by whose authority they were removed Mr. Nidever does not know. One of the Indians, rather dwarfed in intellect, but possessing physical strength equal to those of our ordinary men, remained at San Pedro; two of the women were taken by two Americans living in Los Angeles County; the remainder of the party divided, part going to Los Angeles and part to San Gabriel Mission. The two men who assisted their partners from the party took an active part in forcing the Indians to leave the island.

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An Indian woman was almost gathering wood when the others were taken away, but returned to the camp or quarters, and, finding them deserted, followed in time to be taken aboard the schooner; but, not finding her children there, and a babe of the breast and the other about three years old, she plunged into the water and swam ashore in search of them. Unable to find them, she returned to the beach just in time to see the schooner leaving. She called to those on board, but the only reply she got, and which she remembered to this day of her death, was "mama," pronounced mah-mah-mah, the Spanish word for "to-morrow," evidently meaning that the schooner would return for her to-morrow or the following day. She threw herself down on the beach and cried long and bitterly. She did not find her children, and supposed they were either taken off with the others or carried away and devoured by the wild dogs on the island. She became very sick, and lay a long time (she could not remember time) without either water or food, but finally recovered, and forgot her grief in wandering about the island. She lived on a plant resembling the cabbage, called by Californians "pachamada," and a root known by the name of "paracutia;" also a yellow root, the name of which was not given, and seal or sealion blubber. As she had various shell fish-hooks, and lines made of the sinews of the seal, it is probable she supplied herself with fish of the coast.

An approaching storm, and night coming on, the water being quite shoal about the island and unsafe for a vessel during a high wind, those in charge of the *Fort San Nicks* were compelled to leave for the safety of the ship, intending to return at a future time for the deserted woman. The vessel ran before the gale and reached San Pedro harbor in safety. But circumstances did not permit a return call at the loss of the schooner to a shore

the vessel was driven ashore, and was driven a short distance prior to the loss of the schooner in a storm a few weeks later, and the distance to the island was too great to be safely made in the small shore boat.

In 1881 Mr. Nibley visited the island after hunting, and saw signs of a human inhabitant. He saw a footprint made during the previous rainy season, which was deeply in the now dry, hard ground, and from the size, judged it to be that of a woman. Also there were small circular inclosures about two hundred yards from the beach, and about a mile apart. They were about six feet in diameter, made of brush, the walls five feet high, with a small opening on one side. Near these openings were sticks of deliverted stick in the ground in the form of a tripod, supporting dried seal blubber. These inclosures appeared to be simply wind-breaks, affording no protection from the rain. The investigation was pursued no further, as an approaching storm compelled them to leave the island. Mr. Nibley, having seen many others on his first trip to the island, made a second during the winter of 1882, and being requested by the Mission Fathers of Santa Barbara, had determined to make a careful hunt for the supposed man-inhabitant of the island. The head of the island being better supplied with fresh water than in that portion of the beach affording the best facilities for fishing, and the altitude such as to command a view of the greater portion of the island and coast, he supposed, if alive, she would be found there, and made his arrangements accordingly. He and his party found the same, or similar, inclosures above mentioned, and the tripod sticks supporting reversed pieces of blubber. In the neighbourhood of the huts or wind breaks were seven or eight wild dogs, about the size of a coyote (a small wolf on this coast), and in color, black and white. Mr. Nibley said he had seen the same kind of dogs on the North coast

Indians. They appeared to be very wild. Within half a mile of the head of the island they discovered a basket in the crotch of a bush, or small tree, covered with seal-skin, and containing a dress made of dog's skins (the skin is a species of dog that can neither walk nor fly), carefully folded up, and several square pieces of skin similar to those of which the dress was made, a rope made of seal sinews, alaskan shell fish-bones, bone needles, &c. As it was late, and time for them to return to their boat for the night, Mr. N. examined the contents of the basket on the ground, so that on his return he could judge of the presence or absence of the owner by finding them gathered up or remaining as he left them. The following four or more days were busily spent in other hunting, and before the search for the Indian woman was renewed a south-east gale compelled them to seek a more hospitable harbor at the island of San Miguel. A third voyage by Mr. N. and six others, four of whom were Indians from Santa Barbara Mission, was made to the island in July, 1833, and, although other hunting was the main object of the visit, the Indian woman was not forgotten. They landed on the northern side of the island early in the day, and, having selected their camping site, all but the cook started for the head of the island.

Fresh footprints were observed trailing from the beach to the ridge, or higher elevation, but were soon lost in the moss-covered ground, which ended the search for the day. The following day they were more successful. One of the party, Mr. Delaney, discovered the object of their search at a distance, and cautiously approaching in an opposite direction from the Indians of the party, got quite close to her without being observed. She was in one of her poses, or what we call, clothed in a garment made of the skins of the dog, without sleeves, low-necked, and, as observed when standing, extending ab-

large, white, shaggy, long-haired animal, as observed when standing, extending almost to the ankles. She was sitting cross-legged, skinning and basting with a crude knife made of a piece of soap iron driven into a piece of wood. There was no covering on her head excepting a thick mass of matted hair of a yellowish-brown color, due to the exposure to the sun and air. The hair was short, looking as though the free ends had matted off. She would occasionally raise her head, shade her eyes and look toward the beach, where she evidently saw those from whom Mr. Deussen had recently separated. There were two or three of the wild dogs around the house, which began to growl as Mr. Deussen approached, but ran off at the bidding of their mistress. The harness of the party were now disposed, in order that she might be captured if she attempted to escape. To the surprise of all, she made no attempt to get away, but greeted each one as he approached with a bow and a smile, and chattered all the while in a dialect which none of them understood, although the Indians accompanying Mr. Deussen were acquainted with several Indian dialects. She was talking apparently to herself from the time Mr. Deussen approached until leaving until she was made aware of her presence.

Within the distance a few rods from the house, and a large native vehicle showed that he have been her abiding-place for some time. She was very hospitable—preparing a meal from her limited store of food before called, and serving the party with a grace and bearing that surprised them all. The complexion of her face was blinding, and her features were regular. Her complexion was much fairer and her hair more symmetrical than that of the Indian women on the main land, and she is believed to have belonged to a different and superior race, which opinion is strengthened by the fact that whenever

Louis de Omeza, a Frenchman, now engaged in collecting archaeological and other specimens of bygone years on the Pacific Coast of North and South America for a Paris museum, has found many things on the island San Nicolas similar to those previously collected in Oregon, Washington Territory, and farther north, and unlike any thing found either on the main land or the other islands. Also the skulls and other bones of the human skeletons found there are unlike those found in other sections of Southern California. Near her quarters were several stakes, between which was stretched a rope made of the seal's sinews, supporting seal and seal skinned fish-bone. Farther on were three fish made of whale ribs, covered with bones, but giving no evidence of having been lately occupied. By signs and other means of communication she was made aware that they wanted her to accompany them, and without any apparent hesitation she made ready to follow. She filled a basket—such as were common among the Indians of this coast for packing on their backs—with provisions, fishing-tackle and other articles, and taking it on one arm, and a harpoon in the other hand, she followed the company.

In their course to where the salmon lay at anchor, they found a beautiful spring of water issuing from the rock above the beach, under a shelving rock. The cracks or fissures in this rock were stuck full of bones, and there were other evidences of an encampment of the late inhabitants of the island. These bones were used for ornament, obtained by washing; they had been dried and smoothed many times, showing that, occasionally, she was put upon about railroads; but at the time of her discovery, she appeared to have an glaucous, such as it was. She reached all her teeth, but they were worn low—supposed to be due to the chewing of tough and solid articles of food. Her own account is

solid articles of food. Her age appeared to be about fifty years. Further on was another spring, near the beach, under the bank. Here she indicated a desire to bathe, and was permitted to do so by the balance of the party retiring out of sight. After her bath she joined the others and went direct to the shore boat, and thence to the schooner. She was prevailed upon to abandon her distressed and wet habitar before leaving the beach. Going aboard the vessel, she went directly to the stove and warmed herself, indicating that she knew its use. Pharoah, heavily of the food of the crew, appeared to enjoy it, and it agreed with her. Mr. Williams made her a skirt of ticking, with which, and a sailor's cotton shirt and a black necktie, her attire was complete. She assisted in making her dress, but could not see to thread her needle. Her writing was quite rude. She appeared much pleased with her new apparel. The following day she went ashore with the men, who made a temporary shelter for her, which she occupied about a month—the time spent on the island other than hunting. She was quite industrious, carrying wood and water without the being required of her. She appeared contented and happy, frequently singing and chatting to herself. The men could not understand what she said, nor she they; but Mr. N. said it was truly wonderful how she could converse with them by signs. She occupied a portion of her time making water vessels of grass and asphaltum—a substance plentiful on the islands and shore of the main land. The grass was plaited into a shape resembling a dome, but wider at the top, and lined with asphaltum. She would put in several small pieces of the last mentioned substance, then drop on them small pebbles or stones about the size of hulled walnuts, heated sufficiently to melt the asphaltum, and grasping the neck with both hands, the lower end being on the ground, would give it a rapid rotary mo-

apprehensions, and grasping the rock with both hands, the lower end being on the ground, would give it a rapid rotary motion for several rotations and then drop the stone on the ground.

The vessels had a continuous meeting on the beach, and are reported to have been water-tight, the lining even protecting the head of the men when covered with water. She had both stone and earthen vessels in which to boil water and cook if desired. To procure seal blubber she could kill the seals with a stick when engaged swimming themselves, or secure them with her stone ropes. She obtained fire by rubbing two dry sticks together. One of them, partly had a groove along its entire length; the other was pointed, and fitted and fitted in the groove in which it was rubbed rapidly backward and forward until it burned. As usual, a storm compelled the party to leave the strand, and, embarking with their Indian Queen, they were found themselves at sea in a storm. She made signs that she could stop the storm, and obtaining permission, knelt on the deck facing the quarter whence the wind came, and commenced muttering something supposed to be a prayer. She soon got up, and continued the prayer at intervals during the day, apparently without fear; and when the wind began to abate she turned to her fellow-travelers, and, with a smile, made signs that her prayers had been answered.

When they came in sight of Santa Cruz Island, off this coast, she told them by signs what it was, and told them how she had seen from her island ships pass up and down, but never land, and how, the day previous to her discovery, she had seen the Silver party pass in the head of the island. She was afraid to make herself known until she knew that there was no danger to her person. There were many places of concealment on the island, and unless taken unawares she would have been hard to find.

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As she was about to land at Santa Barbara, an ox-bow passed, which delighted her that she talked, laughed, danced and gesticulated; and before that excitement ended a man on horseback approached, which gave her even more pleasure than the ox-bow. At first it was supposed that she thought the man and horse constituted one animal; but when the mistake was soon corrected, her, on landing, she went up to the horse and carefully examined it. The examination gave her additional pleasure. She wanted men to take companions and laughingly required them to look at the horse. She stretched the thumb of the left hand by the index and middle fingers of the right, and moved them to represent the horse and rider as they passed along the beach. She was taken to the house of Mr. Niblack, where she became the center of attraction. The Mission Fathers took a great interest in her—sending to Los Angeles and other places, looking to find some one who understood her dialect, but failed. Even the Paganeros Indians, who were said to have had an acquaintance with the Indians on the island, could not understand her. The family of Mr. N. became very much attached to her, and although the captain of the brig Fremont offered largely for the privilege of taking her to San Francisco and placing her on exhibition, it was refused. Also an offer of \$1,000 from another party for a like purpose was refused. Many people called on her and she received them kindly; but the afternoon was her favorite time for receiving calls, when she would put on her shagreen dress and entertain her callers with a song and a dance. She cared nothing for money—giving it to the children when given to her. She did not wish to sleep in a bed, and when in bed did not desire bed covering, but was careful not to expose her person. Her manners were not rude, and in many things she was more refined than

many things she was more refined than many who enjoy civilised privileges, yet in many things she was very much like a child. She wanted every thing which she saw then appeared pleasant to the eye, or seemed good to the taste; and if fruit was withheld from her she would plead for it in such a childlike manner that it was hard to refuse her. When freed she was in excellent physical condition, strong and active; but the eating of fruit and vegetables brought on a summer complaint in about three weeks after she landed; and that, in connection with an injury of the spine, received by falling from a porch, constituted her life four weeks later, or seven weeks from the time she landed. During her sickness she reluctantly permitted her kind friends to dress her in flannel underclothes, and took her bed under proper covering, but positively refused to return to her because pain died, as was proposed by some of those who called to see her. Her dress of shag-shine, basket, and trinkets, were given to Father Gervaise of the Mission, who, it is said, sent them to Rome.

Attention to civilised life show a greater longevity in the marital and social relations than in solitary and the life of the natives; but here is one who had attained the age of fifty years with a physician testifying that a period in the future might be reached equal to that of the past, that her highest years had been absolutely alone. While the description of the sickness immediately after her description, she reported no illness during the time of her exile. She appeared to enjoy perfect health, with no failure of any of the bodily functions, excepting that of sight, which may have been either hypermetropia or presbyopia; if the former, most likely it was congenital. If the latter, it may have been hastened by the little too much of the power of accommodation for some time. She also said that the power of

disent vision, in commanding a view of the island and looking seaward. The entrance of land and road are unknown on the islands off this coast; food is seldom seen in the whale, and the food of summer is not oppressive, owing to the ocean winds, which give a most equable climate the year round, favorable to an outdoor life. During the early season she probably took shelter in a cave, or under overhanging rocks, as found upon the island: but be that as it may, the vicissitudes of the weather did not appear to affect her unpleasantly. Her outdoor life gave a digestion equal to the test of the most hardy, and her supply of the most varied of vegetables sustained in nourishing her without deranging the system. On the island, surrounded at important points in length and averaging about four in width, the highest elevations being not more than six hundred feet above sea-level, but sparsely timbered, with its rocks, sandy plains, and limited vegetation, clear spring water, which invited repeated abstractions, with no roof to intercept the warm rays of the sun, our Danish Consul consumed and used the means conducive to a long life. But the change from such a life to one of more luxury and indulgence soon denuded the penalty of the violated laws of health—dyspepsia and death!